



He can feel the eyes. The boy, pathetic in Lila's memory, some victim of the folly of the Sword and his saboteurs. That young man should be of no concern in the face of all the rest there is to do. And yet, Thrast feels *watched*.

Thrust descends to where Lila waits, having wrought some ruin for herself and bearing only malice towards him. He drifts down to either cajole or console her—he is not sure which—but piercing through her own glare are the eyes of her brother.

His hair tousled by a wind Thrast does not feel. His cheeks lit by flames Thrast cannot see. If this boy, David, is somewhere within Veneth's embrace then the location is barred to Thrast. But the boy, he can see.

There is anger there, and fear, but they do not even nudge the irises of David's eyes.

In a contest of wills, there is often a benefit to knowing how you will meet the gaze of your opponent. Consider their strategy, and the limits of their perspective, and pick them apart as they try to hold their own in the confrontation.

Even against the likes of the Realmshorn Thrast has been a master of commanding the flow of an exchange. But for some reason, he can come to no conclusion about how to position himself in the face of this boy. Whatever binds the two of them does nothing to link their thoughts. It leaves no vulnerability to the boy for Thrast to slip a creeper through.

David asks, "Are you worth all this?"

And Thrast feels his manufactured body flare and become ashes. David and Lila and Earth vanish to him, and all that Thrast knows is the storm-winds that raised him as a child dashing the casing of his amber pendant to the sands.

END PART ONE

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